

	Indian Society for Training and Development Student Chapter		
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SpeakUp Showdown - Group Discussion Workshop

Event Overview:

On 24th October 2024, the ISTD Student Chapter of SVCE hosted the SpeakUp Showdown: Master the Art of Group Discussions and Compete for the Crown at the Function Hall, SVCE. This event aimed at transforming participants into skilled communicators and confident group discussion (GD) champions. Designed to provide hands-on experience, the workshop was tailored to help participants excel in professional and academic settings, especially during job interviews and competitive discussions.

Event Structure:

The event opened with a short introduction, followed by an engaging session led by the guest speaker, Raghuram A. His expertise in project management and team collaboration made the session rich in practical insights. He explained that mastering a group discussion goes beyond just speaking confidently; it requires critical thinking, adaptability, analytical skills, and an ability to emphasize and understand others' perspectives.

Participants were guided through the key aspects of group discussions, focusing on:

- **Body language:** How non-verbal cues play a significant role in shaping perceptions during discussions.
- **Adaptability:** The importance of staying flexible and open to different viewpoints to contribute to a more productive discussion.
- **Critical thinking:** Encouraging participants to approach the discussion with an analytical mindset.

- **Listening and engagement:** Teaching the participants that a successful GD is not just about speaking, but also about actively listening and engaging with others' contributions.

Raghuram emphasized that understanding others' viewpoints is crucial in creating a collaborative environment, making group discussions more constructive and fruitful. His calm demeanor and real-life examples kept the participants thoroughly engaged.



Hands-On Group Discussion Sessions:

After the introductory talk, the participants were divided into small groups of 6-8 members. Each group was given a specific topic for their discussion, encouraging a dynamic exchange of ideas. The topics were chosen to stimulate critical thinking and allowed the participants to put into practice the skills they had just learned.

During the discussions, the participants demonstrated their ability to engage in thoughtful debates, express ideas clearly, and listen actively to others. The speaker and organizers observed each group's performance, evaluating them on several criteria such as:

- Clarity of thought and expression.
- Leadership and initiative.
- Team collaboration.
- Critical thinking and problem-solving.



The Prize Announcement:

The event concluded with a prize distribution ceremony, recognizing the top three participants based on their overall performance in the GDs .

- 1st Prize: Vishal Sundaram (ECE, 2nd Year)



Vishal stood out for his excellent leadership and communication skills during the group discussions. His ability to steer the discussion towards a collaborative conclusion impressed both the judges and his fellow participants. In his feedback, he mentioned how the topics were highly relevant to real-life scenarios, which helped him focus on contributing effectively to the discussion. He praised the guest speaker's calm and engaging style for keeping the event interesting.



- 2nd Prize: Srivarthini (Mechanical, 3rd Year)

This was Srivarthini's first GD experience, but her adaptability and critical thinking made her a standout participant. She highlighted the importance of understanding others' perspectives, as emphasized by the guest speaker, and noted how it fostered a more inclusive and productive group discussion. Srivarthini expressed that the session gave her invaluable insights that she would carry forward in future discussions and interviews.

- 3rd Prize: Yajnesh Juttu Sundaram (ECE, 2nd Year)



Yajnesh's insightful contributions and thoughtful engagement with his team earned him the third prize. He praised the organizers for making the event interactive and engaging and suggested that moving future events to the Library Seminar Hall would enhance the professional atmosphere and focus.

Highlights and Feedback:

The interactive nature of the event was a recurring theme in the feedback from participants. They appreciated the practical, hands-on approach, which allowed them to apply the insights they had just learned in real-time discussions. Raghuram's detailed explanation of how to

approach group discussions strategically — from body language to critical thinking — helped participants better understand the nuances of this vital skill.

Suggestions for Improvement:

One of the suggestions, offered by Yajnesh Juttu Sundaram, was to consider relocating future workshops to the Library Seminar Hall to create a more professional atmosphere that would help participants focus and engage more deeply.

Conclusion:

The SpeakUp Showdown was a resounding success, fulfilling its goal of helping participants sharpen their GD skills. With insightful guidance from the guest speaker and the opportunity to practice in a supportive environment, attendees left the event feeling more confident and prepared for future group discussions. The event's interactive format, combined with constructive feedback, provided a comprehensive learning experience that was both enjoyable and educational.

The ISTD Student Chapter looks forward to hosting more such impactful events, aiming to continue fostering communication excellence among its participants.

PREPARED BY:

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